

TICKET TO KERALA
The Story of Malayalam Cinema
By S.R. Praveen
RUPA
₹495; 320 pages

CINEMA ▼

BEYOND THE SCREEN

S.R. PRAVEEN'S *TICKET TO KERALA* IS AN ENGAGING PRIMER ON MALAYALAM CINEMA'S REMARKABLE EVOLUTION

and that content is the star here.

"It is probably because of the industry's inherent limitations that it sustains quality consistently," says Syam Pushkaran, one of the leading writers in Malayalam cinema. "Big studios or corporate houses have yet to be successful here, because the formula, or the lack of it, is tough for them to crack." It's a pertinent observation and one that requires deliberation. But answering the whys is not what *Ticket to Kerala* intends to do.

Much like the movies, the book is divided into two halves. There's the 'New Wave', where Praveen shines a light on creators like Pushkaran, Basil Joseph, Lijo Jose Pellisserry and Dileesh Pothan, whose works have infused vigour into the industry. The second digs into the past, offering a dummy's guide to the history of Malayalam cinema and the key figures who shaped it, and pays tribute to several iconic films.

Ticket to Kerala works best if you are looking for a list of recommended films, the sort that aren't easily accessible on OTT. Praveen covers a lot of ground, including the formation of the Women's Cinema Collective and the challenges female professionals still face despite being in an industry that, for many, champions progressive cinema. While heavy on information, it falls short on insight. The decision to include long interviews is a device that doesn't always work, disrupting the rhythm.

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The most revelatory bit here is the presence of film societies all across the state and the significance of the International Film Festival of Kerala (IFFK) in exposing its audience to world cinema. It best explains why Kerala filmgoers make for discerning viewers who don't settle for the formulaic. ■

—Suhani Singh



IN AWE Actor Adarsh Gourav, host and narrator of *Voices of the Land*; (inset) Megha Ramaswamy

DOCUMENTARY ▲

Untold Stories

Filmmaker **Megha Ramaswamy** captures the wisdom and living traditions of Northeast India's indigenous communities in her documentary series, *Voices of the Land*, which is streaming now on JioHotstar

That strain of storytelling lies at the heart of her latest project, *Voices of the Land*, now streaming on JioHotstar. The six-part documentary series journeys through the forests, mountains and river valleys of Northeast India, offering an intimate glimpse into the lives, traditions and ecological wisdom of some of the country's oldest indigenous communities. "What began as a straightforward exploration series gradually evolved into something slower, more patient, and rooted in respectful observation," reflects Ramaswamy.

As the team travelled through remote tribal communities during the research phase, the focus shifted from simply documenting lives to collaborating deeply with the local voices of these communities, and ensuring that the storytelling itself remained responsible. "We wanted to engage with their worlds responsibly and authentically without fetishising or exoticising their meaningful ancient cultures and practices," she says.

With *Voices of the Land*, Ramaswamy hopes audiences move beyond long-held stereotypes about Northeast India. "I hope it encourages people to see the Northeast with greater curiosity and respect," she points out. Above all, she hopes travellers learn from indigenous communities' deep commitment to conservation and develop a greater respect for the fragile ecosystems they call home. ■

—Deepa Natarajan Lobo